Hebrew Alphabet, Perek Shirah and Pirkei Avot

an appendix to the Kabbalah of Time

FIRST CYCLE

Alef & Bet

Rosh Hashanah to First Days of Sukkot

The Heavens and the Earth

1. The world was created with ten utterances. What does this come to teach us? Certainly, it could have been created with a single utterance. However, this is in order to make the wicked accountable for destroying a world that was created with ten utterances, and to reward the righteous for sustaining a world that was created with ten utterances.

2. There were ten generations from Adam to Noah. This is to teach us the extent of G-d's tolerance; for all these generations angered Him, until He brought upon them the waters of the Flood.

There were ten generations from Noah to Abraham. This is to teach us the extent of G-d's tolerance; for all these generations angered Him, until Abraham came and reaped the reward for them all.

The first set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Alef and Beit, as well as the Heavens and the Earth in Perek Shirah. This cycle includes the days of Creation, as well as Rosh Hashanah itself, running until the middle of Sukkot.

The Talmud teaches that Alef Beit together stand for Aluf Binah (learn understanding). The current week of the year, Week 51, is the week of Binah).

Alef, the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet, stands for the Alufoh Shel Olam, the Master of the World, Hashem. Its shape is formed by two yuds and a vav. The yud above represents G-d and the yud below represents the yid, the Jew. The vav that connects the two is Emunah, faith.

Beit, the second letter, stands for Bayit, home. Midrash Tanchuma teaches that G-d created the world because He desired a dwelling place in the lower realms. Beit is also the first letter of the Torah, which begins with the a description of Creation: "Bereshit Barah Elokim Et HaShamayim Ve'Et Ha'Aretz," "In the beginning, G-d

created Heaven and Earth. The Beit represents the relationship between G-d and the Jewish people, and the Torah itself serves as a link to bind the Jewish people to G-d.

Heaven and Earth refer back to the opening verse of the Torah, mentioned above. The verses themselves also hint to similar themes as above:

The Heavens are saying: "The heavens speak of G-d's glory, and the skies tell of His handiwork."

As mentioned in the very last set of the year, which overlaps with this one and also includes Rosh Hashanah, "Everything that G-d created in His world, He did not create but for His glory." (Pirkei Avot, 6:11) In the last set, the Grasses sing a verse that it almost identical to that of the Heavens: "May the glory of G-d endure forever, may G-d rejoice in His works." (Psalms 104:31)

The Earth is saying, "The earth and everything in it are G-d's; the inhabited area and all that dwell within it." (Psalms 24:1) And it is saying: "From the wings of the land we have heard song, glory to the righteous." (Isaiah 24:16)

The verse of the Earth speaks of the world as a dwelling place, and G-d's ownership over it, including its dwellers. The second verse appears to link G-d's glory to that of the Tzadik, the one that follows in G-d's ways and that of the Torah. As also mentioned in the last set of the year (which includes Rosh Hashanah), G-d Himself is righteous, and on Rosh Hashanah we pray to be judged as Tzadikim, and inscribed in the Book of Life.

SECOND CYCLE

Gimmel & Dalet

First Days of Sukkot to Mid-Cheshvan

Eden & Gehennom (Purgatory)

3. With ten tests our father Abraham was tested and he withstood them all--in order to make known how great was our father Abraham's love [for G-d].

4. Ten miracles were performed for our forefathers in Egypt, and another ten at the sea. Ten afflictions were wrought by G-d upon the Egyptians in Egypt, and another ten at the sea. With ten tests our forefathers tested G-d in the desert, as is stated (Numbers 14:22), "They tested Me these ten times, and did not hearken to My voice."

The second set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar, which parallel the letters Gimmel and Dalet, as well as the Garden of Eden and Gehennom (Purgatory).

Gimmel and Dalet have an interesting relationship. Together, they stand for the idea of "Gommel Dalim," helping the poor. "Dal" means poor in Hebrew. It is a well known idea tht Gimmel is shaped in such a way that represents its running toward the "Dal," the letter Dalet.

The Garden of Eden and Gehennom have a similar kind of relationship on a spiritual plane. Gehennom is often translated as "hell," but hell and eternal damnation are not really a Jewish ideas. Judaism believes that a soul usually must undergo some form of cleansing before entering Heaven, and this cleansing takes place in Gehennom.

To some extent, the Garden of Eden represents spiritual richness, while Gehennom represents spiritual lacking. This is reflected in the verses that these elements sing:

The Garden of Eden is saying, "Arouse yourself, O north [wind], and come, O south! Blow upon my garden, let its spices flow out; let my Beloved come to His garden and eat of its precious fruit." (Song of Songs 4:16)

Gehinnom is saying: “For He has satisfied the longing soul, and has filled the hungry soul with good.” (Psalms 107:9)

These two elements also appear to clearly represent what is about to take place in the next 22 days. We’ll still be in the midst of the holiday season, fully cleansed and joyous after Yom Kippur and fully engaged in the mitzvot of Sukkah and Lulav, which are very much linked to the Garden of Eden. The “mitzvah fruit” of these days, the Etrog, is said to have the smell of the Garden of Eden. We also shake the Lulav north and south (as well as in the other directions, East, West, up and down), as in the song above.

Following the holiday and Tishrei, we enter Cheshvan, which is called “Mar Cheshvan,” “Bitter” Cheshvan, because it lacks any holidays (for now). We therefore use all our spiritual resources acquired in Tishrei to “enrich” the month of Cheshvan, infusing this month and the physical world as a whole with spirituality.

THIRD CYCLE

Heh & Vav

Mid-Cheshvan to Rosh Chodesh Kislev

The Desert & The Fields

5. Ten miracles were performed for our forefathers in the Holy Temple: No woman ever miscarried because of the smell of the holy meat. The holy meat never spoiled. Never was a fly seen in the slaughterhouse. Never did the High Priest have an accidental seminal discharge on Yom Kippur. The rains did not extinguish the wood-fire burning upon the altar. The wind did not prevail over the column of smoke [rising from the altar]. No disqualifying problem was ever discovered in the Omer offering, the Two Loaves or the Showbread. They stood crowded but had ample space in which to prostrate themselves. Never did a snake or scorpion cause injury in Jerusalem. And no man ever said to his fellow "My lodging in Jerusalem is too cramped for me."

6. Ten things were created at twilight of Shabbat eve. These are: the mouth of the earth [that swallowed Korach]; the mouth of [Miriam's] well; the mouth of [Balaam's] ass; the rainbow; the manna; [Moses'] staff; the shamir; the writing, the inscription and the tablets [of the Ten Commandments]. Some say also the burial place of Moses and the ram of our father Abraham. And some say also the spirits of destruction as well as the original tongs, for tongs are made with tongs.

The third set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Heh and Vav, as well as the Desert and the Field in Perek Shirah.

Just as Gimmel and Dalet have an interesting relationship, so too do the letters Heh and Vav. Heh is female, and represents the Divine attribute (sefirah) of Malchut. The letter Heh also it tied to the concept of pregnancy, as it is the first letter in the Hebrew word for it, Herayon. The shape of the Heh is also that of a Dalet with a Yud "impregnated" inside. Of all the sefirot, Malchut does not give, but only receives - that is why it is called a "poor" sefirah, because "she has nothing of her own" (De'leit

Lah, like the letter Dalet). The Dalet represents an unrectified feminine aspect, while the Heh, represents a rectified one.

The Furthermore, Heh, spelled out in full, appears in the verse, "Heh Lachem Zerah," take for yourselves seed. (Genesis 47:23):

The Magen David and the Kli Yakar interpret the words "Hei lachem zerah" to mean, 'Take the letter Hei () for yourselves for zerah.' The word zerah, 'seed', often means 'children'. Therefore, the letter Hei is connected with fertility and having chidren. This is why G-d changed our matriarch Sarah's name. When the Yud in the name Sarai was changed to a Hei, spelling Sarah–she soon became pregnant with Yitzchak. (http://www.bnaiavraham.com/learning/weekly-parsha/vayigash-sowing-seeds-of-redemption/)

The Vav is male, and symbolizes the sefirah of Yesod (foundation) as well as all of Zeir Anpin, the six masculine emotional Divine attributes (sefirot) that come prior to Malchut, which is female. The shape of the Vav is a straight line, which is associated with male qualities, while female qualities are associated with round, curved shapes, like that of the Heh.

Furthermore, the Vav, which literally means a "hook," grammatically is a letter that connects and transformed. A Vav preceding a word usually means "and." If that word is a verb, the Vav can transform it from past tense to future tense, or vice-versa.

The 22 days of this cycle usually fall mostly within the month of Cheshvan, and start around the time of the yahrzeit of Rachel Immeinu, our matriarch. In Kabbalistic literature, Rachel symbolizes the sefirah of Malchut. As explained previously, Cheshvan is a "poor" month, waiting to be impregnated with the holiness we obtained during Tishrei.

The Heh therefore represents the time in the month of Cheshvan that stands for a "rectified" Malchut, when the initial spiritual void we encountered has already been somewhat filled with spirituality.

The cycle also includes the first days of Kislev, the month of Chanukah, and which is also filled with Chassidic holidays, such as the 19th of Kislev (the Rosh Hashanah of Chasidut) and others. The Vav therefore connects us to the time in which we stood our ground (Yesod) against Greek culture, and transformed darkness into light.

The Desert and the Field have a similar kind of relationship. The Desert also represents the idea of "poverty," be it spiritual or physical, a deep desire for water (Torah). The Desert however, although still symbolic of the bitterness of exile, is already great "step up" from the previous element, Gehennom (purgatory). We are already at a more rectified level of exile.

The Fields are another step closer to elevation. The fields contain even more life and spirituality. Fields are associated with Isaac, who would converse with G-d in the field. As also explained in other places, of the two sons of Isaac, it is Eisav who is called a "man of the field," while Jacob was a wholesome man who would dwell in the tent (of study). In exile, Jacob must learn to be a man of the field as well.

It is also worth noting the progression in the Torah regarding how each of our patriarchs related to the place of the Temple, Mount Moriah. Avraham saw it as a mountain, Isaac as a field, while Jacob knew it as Beit-El, G-d's home (R. Ari Jacobson, YU). A similar progression exists in Perek Shirah, in transforming the world from Gehennom, to a Desert, to a Field.

The desire for water, associated with Desert, also coincides with the time when the Flood began, on the 17th of Cheshvan. Also, the elements of the coming 22-day cycles will be related to water.

The above is reflected in the verses that the two elements sing:

The Wilderness (Desert) is saying, "The wilderness and the desert shall rejoice, and the arid region shall exult, and blossom like the rose." (Isaiah 35:1)

The Fields are saying, "God founded the land with wisdom; He established the heavens with understanding." (Proverbs 3:19)

The Desert sings of its desire for water (Torah), and the day it will be completely rectified in the Messianic era. The Fields speak of foundation (Yesod) and wisdom (Chochmah), the quality most associated with Greek culture, and one of its biggest threats in the time of Chanukah. Many aspects of Greek wisdom and reasoning, however, when properly incorporated into Jewish values, have proven immensely beneficial. (See Maimonedes, and also how Talmai ("Ptolomy," the Greek leader at the time), has the same gematria as "Talmud.")

FOURTH CYCLE

Zayin & Chet

Rosh Chodesh Kislev to Chanukah

The Waters & The Seas

7. There are seven things that characterize a boor, and seven that characterize a wise man. A wise man does not speak before one who is greater than him in wisdom or age. He does not interrupt his fellow's words. He does not hasten to answer. His questions are on the subject and his answers to the point. He responds to first things first and to latter things later. Concerning what he did not hear, he says "I did not hear." He concedes to the truth. With the boor, the reverse of all these is the case.

8. Seven types of retribution come to the world, for seven types of sin. When some tithe and others don't, a hunger caused by turmoil ensues: some are hungry, others have their fill of food. When all are unanimous in their failure to tithe, a hunger by drought ensues. For not separating chalah, an annihilating hunger results.

Plagues come to the world for those capital crimes mentioned in the Torah that have not been given over to the court, and for desecrating the produce of the sabbatical year.

The sword comes to the world for the procrastination of justice, the corruption of justice, and because of those who misinterpret the Torah.

The fourth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Zayin and Chet, as well as the Waters and the Seas in Perek Shirah.

Just as we saw with Gimmel and Dalet and then with Heh and Vav, the letters Zayin and Chet are also complementary. Zayin represents Creation, the physical struggles connected to it as well as the spirituality within it, such as the Shabat. Zayin means weapon, and Zan means to provide (materially). There is a deep connection between making a living and going to battle. The word for Lechem (bread/sustenance) is also found in the word Milchama (war). (See Rabbi Michael Munk's, "Wisdom of the Hebrew Letters")

Chet, on the other hand, represents tremendous power and inner qualities that are above nature. Chet stands for Cheit (sin), but also the ability to overcome sin and live (Chaim). (Id.) Rebbe Nachman of Breslov, in the opening pages of Likutei Moharan, explains that Cheit is Chiut (vitality), which is also the inner wisdom (Chochmah) and thinking (Sechel).

The Water and the Seas have a similar kind of relationship. Water is the source of life in all the physical world. We ourselves are made of mostly water. Yet water also represents the Torah, and is deeply connected to all things spiritual. The Waters sing: "The sound of His voice places the multitude of waters in the heavens and He raises the vapors from the end of the earth." (Jeremiah 51:16) Water is connected to both heaven and earth; the material as well as the spiritual.

The Seas represent tremendous awe-inspiring might, deep below the surface, yet reflecting also G-d's tremendous heights. The Seas say: "More than the voices of many waters, mightier than the breakers of the sea, Hashem is mighty on high." (Psalms 93:4) The Seas also represent inner wisdom, waiting to be revealed, like in the splitting of the Sea of Reeds in our redemption from Egypt. (See Rabbi Slifkin's, "Nature's Song")

The 22 days of this cycle all fall within Kislev. Kislev represents the month of the physical and spiritual struggle against the Greeks. It is also a month very much connected with supernatural redemption (ie. the 8 days of Chanukah) as well as deep supernatural kabbalistic secrets, such as those revealed on the 19th of Kislev - the Rosh Hashanah of Chasidut and the personal redemption of the Alter Rebbe of Lubavitch.

FIFTH CYCLE

Tet & Yud

From First Days of Chanukah to Mid-Tevet

The Rivers & The Wellsprings

9. Carnage by wild beasts comes to the world for false oaths and the desecration of Gd's name.

Exile comes to the world for idol-worship, sexual promiscuity, murder and the failure to leave the land fallow on the sabbatical year.

There are four time-periods when plagues increase: on the fourth and seventh years [of the sabbatical cycle], on the year following the seventh, and following the festivals of each year. On the fourth year, because of [the neglect of] the tithe to the poor that must be given on the third year; on the seventh, because of the tithe to the poor that must be given on the sixth; on the year after the seventh, because of the produce of the sabbatical year; and following each festival, because of the robbing of the poor of the gifts due to them.

10. There are four types of people: One who says, "What is mine is yours, and what is yours is mine" is a boor. One who says "What is mine is mine, and what is yours is yours" -- this is a median characteristic; others say that this is the character of a Sodomite. One who says, "What is mine is yours, and what is yours is yours" is a chassid (pious person). And one who says "What is mine is mine, and what is yours is mine" is wicked.

The fifth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Tet and Yud, as well as the Rivers and the Wellsprings in Perek Shirah.

Just as we saw with the previous pairs, Tet and Yud are also complementary. Tet is connected to the Hebrew word Tov, good, which in turn is generally connected to the Torah and to light. Tet also means snake in Aramaic, which represents desire, as well as physicality in general. Connecting the two concepts, Tet is connected to the hidden good, as our sages comment that the Torah refers to the good inclination as

good, and the evil inclination as “very good.” (Rabbi Raskin, “Letters of Light: Tet” http://www.chabad.org/multimedia/media_cdo/aid/2018348/jewish/Letters-of-Light-Tet.htm)

Yud represents spirituality. It is simply a dot on the page. The Heavens are said to have been created with the letter Yud. The Yud also generally represents wisdom. It is also connected to the pintele yid, the spiritual essence of every Jew, which if one digs deep enough one will certainly find.

The Rivers and the Wellsprings have a similar relationship. As explained previously, water in general is a symbol of Torah. The Rivers also represent physical life - not only is the water drinkable (which can be used for irrigation), but rivers are usually full of fish, as well as other fauna and flora that are a great source of sustenance for those near it.

Wellsprings represent spirituality as well. They also come about through much digging (like the wells of Isaac). The Baal Shem Tov had a vision in which he encountered Mashiach and asked him he would come. The answer: “When the your wellsprings have spread outwards.”

The 22 days of this cycle all fall within Chanukah as well as the beginning of Teveth, including the fast of the Tenth of Teveth. Chanukah is about the victory of Torah and light over Greek wisdom and darkness. Teveth, the coldest month of the year, is known as the time when “the body benefits from the body.” This is connected to physical desire and the snake, as mentioned above. The month of Teveth is represented by the tribe of Dan, which has the snake as its symbol.

The Lubavitcher Rebbe explains that the concept of “the body benefits from the body,” has also a very spiritual dimension. It is about how the essence of the Jewish people connects to the essence of G-d. This is connected to the idea of digging and finding the spiritual within the mundane and the spread outward of the wellsprings of the Ba’al Shem Tov.

The tenth of Teveth has the potential for being an incredibly happy and spiritual day. This potential is connected to another fast which is also on the tenth of the month, Yom Kippur, and will be fulfilled with the coming of Mashiach.

SIXTH CYCLE

Kaf & Lamed

From Mid-Tevet to Yud Shvat

Day and Night

11. There are four types of temperaments. One who is easily angered and easily appeased--his virtue cancels his flaw. One whom it is difficult to anger and difficult to appease--his flaw cancels his virtue. One whom it is difficult to anger and is easily appeased, is a chassid. One who is easily angered and is difficult to appease, is wicked.

12. There are four types of student. One who is quick to understand and quick to forget--his flaw cancels his virtue. One who is slow to understand and slow to forget--his virtue cancels his flaw. One who is quick to understand and slow to forget--his is a good portion. One who is slow to understand and quick to forget--his is a bad portion.

The sixth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Kaf and Lamed, as well as the Day and the Night in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period begins in Teveth and runs through almost half of Shevat.

Kaf is connected to the Hebrew word Keter, crown, which in Kabbalah is connected to those aspects of the soul that are above intellect: Emunah (faith), Ta'anug (pleasure), and Ratzon (desire). Kaf also means the palm of the hand, or a spoon, both of which are slightly bent in order to serve as a receptacle, a kli (which is also with the letter Kaf).

Lamed is the root of the words Lilmod (to study) and Lelamed (to teach). The Lamed is particularly connected with the Oral Torah, the part of the Torah which was never intended to be written down, but instead was transmitted orally from teacher to student.

In Kabbalah, the Day is connected to intellect, while the night represents that which is above intellect, particularly Emunah, faith. These concepts can be found in

the verses each of the two sing in Perek Shirah:

The Day is saying: "Day to day utters speech, and night to night relates knowledge." (Psalms 19:3)

The Night is saying: "To speak of His kindness in the morning, and of His faithfulness by nights." (Psalm 92:3)

The Hebrew word for knowledge is Da'at, which in Kabbalah is interchangeable with Keter. Faithfulness above, in Hebrew, is Emunah.

Teveth is a time of the year where the nights are particularly long and cold, yet around this time is also when the nights slowly start getting shorter again, and the days start getting longer. Our sages tell us that long nights were given in order to study Torah. Traditionally, the Oral Torah is what is studied by night, while the Written Torah is studied only during the day.

Shevat is particularly connected to all of the above. As explained in Book 1, Shevat is connected to the Tribe of Asher, which stands for Ta'anug (pleasure). Shevat is also very much connected to Emunah, given that we celebrate the New Year of the Trees, Tu B'Shvat, in the middle of the winter. Finally, Shevat is connected to the Oral Torah. Moshe began teaching the Oral Torah to the Jewish People during this month, and the Chidushei HaRim teaches that all insights in the Oral Torah for the entire come to a person during the month of Shevat.

SEVENTH CYCLE

Mem & Nun

From Yud Shvat to Rosh Chodesh Adar

Sun and Moon

13. There are four types of contributors to charity. One who wants to give but does not want others to give--is begrudging of others. One who wants that others should give but does not want to give--begrudges himself. One who wants that he as well as others should give, is a chassid. One who want neither himself nor others to give, is wicked.

14. There are four types among those who attend the study hall. One who goes but does nothing--has gained the rewards of going. One who does [study] but does not go to the study hall--has gained the rewards of doing. One who goes and does, is a chassid. One who neither goes nor does, is wicked.

The seventh set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Mem and Nun, as well as the Sun and the Moon in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period begins in Shevat and runs through the beginning of Adar.

Mem is middle letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It's central role is also reflected in Hebrew words for many of the fundamental parts of nature, such as Mother (Em), Water (Mayim), Shamayim (Sky), and Shemesh (Sun). Mem, along with Alef and Shin, is also known as one of the "mother-letters" in Kabbalah.

Nun stands for the Divine attribute (sefirah) of Malchut, Kingship, and is related to one of the names for Mashiach: Yinon. (Likutei Moharan) Nun also means "fish" in Aramaic, and is associated closely with Moshe Rabbeinu. Joshua is called Yehoshua Bin Nun, the son of Nun, because a teacher (in this case, Moshe) is like a parent.

In Kabbalah, the sun is connected to Chochmah, wisdom. The moon is Malchut, as it reflects the light of the sun, in a way that can be absorbed by the naked eye. This phenomenon also very much represents the idea of the Oral Torah. Talmud teaches that Moshe was like the sun, while his disciple, Joshua, was like the moon. (Bava

Batra, 75a)

The Sun is saying: "The sun [when covered by] the moon, stood in its abode; they speed at the light of Your arrows, and at the shining of your glittering spear." (Habakuk 3:11)

The Moon is saying: "He made the moon for the festivals; the sun knows the time of its coming." (Psalm 104:19)

It is fascinating how the song of the sun refers to the moon, while the song of the moon refers to the sun. The sun and the moon represent the ultimately duality, often found in many aspects of nature.

Shevat is very much a celebration of nature. On Tu B'Shvat, we celebrate the New Year of the Trees. As explained previously, Shevat is also very much associated with the Oral Torah.

In the calendar, the sun determines the days, weeks, and seasons, while the moon determines the months. It is around this time of year that the cycles of the sun and the moon have to completely align. That is why often, 7 times every 19 years, the Jewish calendar contains not one, but two months of Adar.

Adar is also very much about duality, particularly the holiday of Purim, which contain so many pairs, sometimes complementary and sometimes antithetical: Mordechai and Esther, Haman and Achashverosh, Mordechai and Haman... Purim, and the mitzvot associated with the day, are also very much tied to the letter Mem: Mishloach Manot, Matanot L'Evionim, Mikrah Megillah, etc. Finally, Adar and Purim in particular is associated with the Sha'ar HaNun, the 50th gate.

Adar is the month of Pisces (fish, Nun). The 7th of Adar is also the date of the birth, as well of the passing, of Moshe Rabbeinu.

EIGHTH CYCLE

Samech & Ayin

from Rosh Chodesh Adar to 24th of Adar

The Stars

15. There are four types among those who sit before the sages: the sponge, the funnel, the strainer and the sieve. The sponge absorbs all. The funnel takes in at one end and lets it out the other. The strainer rejects the wine and retains the sediment. The sieve rejects the coarse flour and retains the fine flour.

16. Any love that is dependent on something--when the thing ceases, the love also ceases. But a love that is not dependent on anything never ceases. What is [an example of] a love that is dependent on something? The love of Amnon for Tamar. And one that is not dependent on anything? The love of David and Jonathan.

The eighth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Samech and Ayin, as well as the Stars in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period falls completely within Adar, including Purim.

Samech stands for "Somech Noflim," "[Hashem] supports the fallen." Its shape is a circle, and stands for the different highs and lows of life. This is very much the theme of Purim. Not only did Hashem support us when we had fallen, but also the story itself comes "full circle," with Mordechai and the Jews (who were down) brought up, and Haman (who was up) brought down.

Ayin means "eye," as well as "well," "fountain," "spring." The eye is known as the "window to the soul," shedding light on a person's inner dimension. Similarly, a wellspring represents the revelation of the hidden, inner spiritual aspects of the earth, its deeper waters. (See Sixth Set of 22-days) This is also one of the themes of the month of Adar, revealing (Megilah) that which is hidden (Esther).

Both above themes, a) relying only on G-d for support, whether in a high or a low, and b) revealing the hidden spirituality with everything, can be found in the song of the Stars:

The Stars are saying, “You, only You, are God; You made heaven, the heaven of heavens, with all their hosts; the earth, and everything that is in it; the seas, and everything that is in them; and You preserve them all; and the host of heaven prostrate themselves to You.” (Nehemiah 9:6)

Stars themselves also offer us a glimpse into the vastness of the universe. They grant us a better sense of our smallness and of G-d’s greatness. The name Esther comes from the word for star. She is referred to in Psalm 22 as Ayelet HaShachar, the “Morning Star.” The morning star is the very last one to shine before daybreak. Similarly, Esther is the last prophet(ess) before the coming of Mashiach and the final redemption.

NINTH CYCLE

Peh and Tzaddik

from 25th of Adar to Pessach

Thick and Light Clouds

17. Any dispute that is for the sake of Heaven is destined to endure; one that is not for the sake of Heaven is not destined to endure. Which is a dispute that is for the sake of Heaven? The dispute(s) between Hillel and Shamai. Which is a dispute that is not for the sake of Heaven? The dispute of Korach and all his company.

18. One who causes the community to be meritorious, no sin will come by his hand. One who causes the community to sin, is not given the opportunity to repent. Moses was meritorious and caused the community to be meritorious, so the community's merit is attributed to him; as is stated, "He did Gd's righteousness, and His laws with Israel" (Deuteronomy 33:21). Jeroboam the son of Nebat sinned and caused the community to sin, so the community's sin is attributed to him; as is stated, "For the sins of Jeroboam, which he sinned and caused Israel to sin" (I Kings 15:30).

The ninth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Peh and Tzadik, as well as the Thick and Thin Clouds in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period comes during the time of Passover preparations, most within the month of Nissan.

Peh means "mouth," which is one of the primary symbols of Passover itself. Rabbi Levi Yitzchak of Berditchev states that Pesach stands for Peh - Sach, a mouth converses, as it is a special mitzvah to recount the miracles of our liberation during the Passover Seder. The Megaleh Amukos states that Pharaoh stands for Peh Rah (evil mouth). (Raskin)

The shape of the letter Peh is a combination of the Kaf and a Yud. The Yud stands for G-dliness, and therefore the Peh symbolizes the revelation of G-dliness. Also, the Yud is like a tooth inside the mouth. In the Haggadah of Passover, we learn that the we must "break the teeth" of the evil son, so that he may become a Tzadik, revealing

his potential.

The next letter, the Tzadik, stands for righteousness. The Tzadik is also a combination of letters: a bent Nun and a Yud. The bent Nun symbolizes humility, the trait most associated with Moshe, of whom the Torah testifies that he was the most humble of men. Humility, destroying one's spiritual Chametz (leavened bread, ego) is certainly one of the main themes of this time as well. It is also through humility that we reveal the Yud, G-dliness.

A similar theme can be found in the Perek Shirah verses of the Thick and Thin Clouds:

The Thick Clouds are saying, "He mad darkness His secret place; His pavilion around Him was dark with waters and thick clouds of the skies." (Psalms 18:12)

The Light Clouds are saying, "Also He burdens the thick cloud with overflow; the [light] cloud scatters its light. (Job 37:11)

The thick, usually dark clouds, symbolize the potential for tremendous rain. This overflow of water (which is always a metaphor for the Torah itself) is very much connected to extensive recounting of the Passover story, as well as the potential fro the evil son to bring tremendous good and blessing to the world.

The light clouds also spread the knowledge of G-d, "scattering His light." The clouds' lightness also appears to symbolize humility. It is their very lightness that allows them to have such strong reflective powers. The same is true for all Tzadikim and the Jewish people as a whole. They are a reflection of G-d's light. In Hebrew, light clouds are called Ananei HaKavod, "Clouds of Glory," the term used for the clouds that protected the Jewish people during the the time of the Exodus from Egypt and the Passover story. The clouds were given to the Jewish people in the merit of Aharon's righteousness. After Aharon passed away, the clouds disappeared. They were later reinstated in the merit of another Tzadik, Moshe Rabbeinu.

TENTH CYCLE

Kuf and Reish

from Pessach to 9th of Iyar

Wind and Lightning Bolts

19. Whoever possesses the following three traits is of the disciples of our father Abraham; and whoever possesses the opposite three traits is of the disciples of the wicked Balaam. The disciples of our father Abraham have a good eye, a meek spirit and a humble soul. The disciples of the wicked Balaam have an evil eye, a haughty spirit and a gross soul. What is the difference between the disciples of our father Abraham and the disciples of the wicked Balaam? The disciples of our father Abraham benefit in this world and inherit the World To Come, and as is stated, "To bequeath to those who love Me there is, and their treasures I shall fill" (Proverbs 8:21). The disciples of the wicked Balaam inherit purgatory and descent into the pit of destruction, as is stated, "And You, Gd, shall cast them into the pit of destruction; bloody and deceitful men, they shall not attain half their days. And I shall trust in you" (ibid., 55:24).

20. Judah the son of Teima would say: Be bold as a leopard, light as an eagle, fleeting as a deer and mighty as a lion to do the will of your Father in Heaven. He would also say: The brazen--to purgatory; the bashful--to paradise. May it be Your will, L-rd our Gd and Gd of our fathers, that the Holy Temple be rebuilt speedily in our days; and grant us our portion in Your Torah.

The tenth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Kuf and Reish, as well as the Wind and Lighting Bolts in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period comes in the middle of the Passover holiday, and extends until the 9th of Iyar, halfway through the counting of the Omer.

Kuf means "monkey," which is one of the primary symbols of impurity, Klippah, which itself begins with a Kuf. The Kuf is shaped like an imperfect Heh (which represents holiness), just like a monkey is an imperfect imitation of a human being.

At the times that we behave properly, the Torah states that five (gematria of Heh) of us will chase one hundred (gematria of Kuf).

On the other hand, Kuf can also stand for holiness itself, Kedushah, which also begins with the letter Kuf. We therefore see that the Kuf has potential for both holiness and unholiness, and represents the process of transformation from unholiness to holiness, just as during these days between Passover and Shavuot the Jews went from the 49th level of unholiness to the 49th level of holiness. Rabbi Yitzchak Ginsburgh in his book, The Hebrew Letters, states that the Kuf represents the kabbalistic concept of "Redemption of Fallen Sparks." (p.280) In Kabbalah, redeeming the holy sparks is the very reason for our existence (Tikkun Olam, "fixing the world"), and the rationale behind our exile(s).

The next letter, the Reish, also represents a similar dual concept. It can stand for Rash (poor) or Rosh (head), just as the month of Nissan itself is both the head of all the months and yet a month of humility in which we eat the bread of poverty. Nissan represent Judah, the head of all the tribes, and yet someone who was humbly willing to accept his shortcomings and transform them. Similar to the Kuf, Rav Ginsburgh states that the Reish stands for Avodat HaBerurim (the service of clarification), which is also very much related to the redemption of the sparks mentioned above. Once the Avodat HaBerurim is completed, Mashiach (son of David, from Judah) will come and bring about the ingathering of the exiles and redemption.

Furthermore, the Zohar mentions that two letters Kuf and Reish together also have a poor connotation. They form part of the word Sheker, a lie. Kuf and Reish by themselves spell Kar, coldness, also associated with impurity (Raskin). Kuf and Reish are also the first two letters of the word Keri, a strong form of impurity associated with seminal emission, as well as with Amalek. Yet, when the last letter of the word Keri, the yud (which, like the Heh, stands for G-dliness) is placed in the beginning, in front of the Kuf and the Reish, it forms the word Yakar, which means "dear." Here too, we see that impurity can be transformed into a feeling of dearness and closeness to G-d.

A similar theme can be found in the Perek Shirah verses of the Wind and the Lightning Bolts:

The Wind is saying, "I will say to the north, Give up; and to the south, Do not withhold; bring My sons from far, and My daughters from the ends of the earth."

(Isaiah 43:6)

The Lightning Bolts are saying, "He causes the vapors to ascend from the ends of the earth; He makes lightning for the rain; He brings forth the wind from His storehouses." (Psalms 135:7)

The verses above are clearly related to the ingathering of the exiles. Both verses speak of the "ends of the earth." This is related to Passover, but also to Yom Ha'Atzma'ut. (See here, how theoretically Yom Ha'Atzma'ut could be celebrated as late as the 9th of Iyar, the 24th day of the Omer).

Wind in Hebrew is "Ruach," which also means spirit. It is a word specifically connected to Mashiach, and the Haftorah we read for the last day of Passover. The verse of the wind specifically addresses two kinds of exile, north (Assyria) and south (Egypt), telling the forces of impurity to "give up" and "not withhold," elevating the sparks and transforming them into holiness.

The Lightning Bolts also bring to mind the miracles of Egypt and the giving of the Torah at Sinai (marked by both thunder and lightning). The verse also speaks of the Lightning Bolts making "vapors" ascend, which seems very much parallel to the concept of elevating the fallen sparks back to their source. In fact, Rav Ginsburgh mentions "vapor" as an aspect of elevating fallen sparks, related to both the Reish itself and the form of the Reish within the Kuf itself (made of a Reish and Zayin). Interestingly, the verse of the Lightning Bolts also mentions the wind.

ELEVENTH CYCLE

Shin and Tav

from 10th of Iyar to 2nd of Sivan

Dew and Rain

21. Ben Bag Bag would say: Delve and delve into it, for all is in it; see with it; grow old and worn in it; do not budge from it, for there is nothing better.

Ben Hei Hei would say: According to the pain is the gain.

22. He would also say: Five years is the age for the study of Scripture. Ten, for the study of Mishnah. Thirteen, for the obligation to observe the mitzvot. Fifteen, for the study of Talmud. Eighteen, for marriage. Twenty, to pursue [a livelihood]. Thirty, for strength, Forty, for understanding. Fifty, for counsel. Sixty, for sagacity. Seventy, for elderliness. Eighty, for power. Ninety, to stoop. A hundred-year-old is as one who has died and passed away and has been negated from the world.

The eleventh set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letters Shin and Tav, as well as the Dew and Rains in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period includes Lag Ba'Omer, Yom Yerushalayim and Rosh Chodesh Sivan (extending until the 2nd of Sivan), immediately prior to the Shlosha Yemei Hagbalah (three days of separation) and Shavuoth.

Shin literally means "tooth," the strongest bone in the human body. It is also one of the "mother" letters of the Hebrew alphabet, and is connected to Esh, fire. The Shin has different ways of being written (sometimes with 4 arms instead of 3), and also has different sounds (sometimes Sh, sometimes S, and sometimes silent). The Shin's numerical value is 300, consistent with its three-armed shape. This fiery letter sometimes has a negative trait. Along with the two letters of the previous cycle, it forms the word Sheker, a lie.

These are fiery times in the Jewish calendar, particularly Lag Ba'Omer (also very much connected to the number 3, as it is the 33rd day of the Omer: Lamed is 30 and Gimmel is 3. Yom Yerushalayim is also connected to fire. Of the 4 holy cities,

Jerusalem is fire. “It was destroyed by fire and will be rebuilt by fire.”

The next and final letter in the Aleph-Bet is the Tav. Is in many ways the opposite of the Shin. It represents Tmimut (wholesomeness), perfection, stability. Along with the “mother” letters Alef (air) and Mem (water), it spells out the word Emet, truth. As the final letter, it represents completion. This cycle is also about completing the Counting of the Omer, which are called Shevah Shabatot Temimot (seven wholesome, complete weeks). Also, as explained in the previous cycle, it is during the counting of the Omer that we transform unholiness into holiness, falsehood (Sheker) into truth (Emet). As we encamp at Mt. Sinai on Rosh Chodesh Sivan, we are settled, stable, and in harmony, prepared to receive the Torah.

A similar theme can be found in the Perek Shirah verses of the Dew and the Rain:

The Dew is saying, “I shall be as the dew to Israel, he shall blossom as a rose, he shall spread forth his roots as the Lebanon.“ (Hoshea 14:6) Other texts add: ”Arouse yourself, O north [wind], and come, O south! Blow upon my garden, let its spices flow out; let my Beloved come to His garden and eat of its precious fruit.“ (Song of Songs 4:16)

The Rains are saying, “You, O Lord, poured a generous rain, to strengthen Your heritage when it languished.” (Psalms 68:10)

Dew represents renewal. It is connected to resurrection of the dead. There is also something called the Tal of Torah. The teachings of Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai revived us. We blossomed like a rose… which are the opening words of the Zohar.

The Dew also connotes a “surprise” redemption, which is independent of our merits. Such was the conquest of Jerusalem and the Six-Day war, in which Israel “spread forth his roots as the Lebanon. The ”Lebanon“ is a known reference to the Temple and Jerusalem.

The additional text also seems related to Lag Ba’omer and Yom Yerushalayim, as it speaks about being aroused from the hidden (North, Tzafon, can also mean Tzafun, hidden), like the hidden knowledge of Kabbalah revealed by Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai. It also speaks of spreading out to the north, south, and to Hashem’s garden, Jerusalem.

Rain is usually conditional on our behavior. It is in this way more connected to the attribute of judgement and truth, like the Tav. However, there are times, like on Yom Yerushalayim, when even rain can fall simply out of Hashem’s generosity, as

well as out of the need to protect His heritage. As we say in the opening lines of the Shmoneh Esreh Prayer... "Elohei Avraham, Elohei Yitzchak, veElohei Ya'akov... uMevi Goel liVnei Bneihem, L'ma'an Shemoh Be'Ahavah" (the G-d of Abraham, the G-d of Isaac and the G-d of Jacob... and Who brings redemption to their children's children, for the sake of His Name, in love). The song of the Rain is also about us feeling strengthened and firmly established, like the encampment by Mt. Sinai.

These last two elements also mark the end of the second chapter of Perek Shirah, and the completion of all the songs of the elements of the mineral kingdom. The following chapters in Perek Shirah relate to trees and to animals.

TWELFTH CYCLE

Kaf Sofit

from 3rd of Sivan to 24th of Sivan

Trees of the Field and the Vine

1. The sages expounded in the language of the Mishnah (blessed is He who chose them and their learning):

Rabbi Meir would say: Whoever studies Torah for Torah's sake alone, merits many things; not only that, but [the creation of] the entire world is worthwhile for him alone. He is called friend, beloved, lover of Gd, lover of humanity, rejoicer of Gd, rejoicer of humanity. The Torah enclothes him with humility and awe; makes him fit to be righteous, pious, correct and faithful; distances him from sin and brings him close to merit. From him, people enjoy counsel and wisdom, understanding and power, as is stated (Proverbs 8:14): "Mine are counsel and wisdom, I am understanding, mine is power." The Torah grants him sovereignty, dominion, and jurisprudence. The Torah's secrets are revealed to him, and he becomes as an ever-increasing wellspring and as an unceasing river. He becomes modest, patient and forgiving of insults. The Torah uplifts him and makes him greater than all creations.

2. Said Rabbi Joshua the son of Levi: Every day, an echo resounds from Mount Horeb (Sinai) proclaiming and saying: "Woe is to the creatures who insult the Torah." For one who does not occupy himself in Torah is considered an outcast, as is stated (Proverbs 11:22), "A golden nose-ring in the snout of a swine, a beautiful woman bereft of reason." And it says (Exodus 32:16): "And the tablets are the work of Gd, and the writing is Gd's writing, engraved on the tablets"; read not "engraved" (charut) but "liberty" (chairut)---for there is no free individual, except for he who occupies himself with the study of Torah. And whoever occupies himself with the study of Torah is elevated, as is stated (Number 21:19), "And from the gift to Nahaliel, and from Nahaliel to The Heights."

The twelfth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the letter Kaf Sofit, as well as the Trees of the Field and the Vine in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period runs from the Shlosha Yemei Hagbalah (three days of separation) and Shavuoth to close to the end of the month of Sivan.

The previous set of 22 days marked the last two letters of the Jewish alphabet, Shin and Tav. However, it is also common to include separately in the Aleph Bet the final letters: Kaf Sofit, Mem Sofit, Nun Sofit, Peh Sofit and Tzadik Sofit. These letters appear stand for the five parts of the mouth related to speech, which are connected to the "Five Gevurot" and the the five primary vowels. (See Rabbi Aryeh Kaplan's translation and commentary to Sefer Yetzirah)

The twelfth cycle of 22 days appears related to the letter Kaf Sofit. As mentioned previously, the Kaf stands for Keter, which is the part of the soul that is associated with that which is above intellect. Kaf literally means the palm of the hand and/or a spoon, which is bent like a receptacle. Unlike the regular Kaf, the Kaf Sofit is not bent, but instead goes straight down.

The giving of the Torah came straight down in a way that penetrated the world, to the extent that on Mount Sinai the words of the Torah did not have an echo (ie. they did not bounce back from what they touched - instead they were absorbed).

The following is from Rabbi Michael Munk's, "The Wisdom of the Hebrew Alphabet:"

The Kaf Sophit, "a long straight letter, indicat[es] that one who succeeds in bending his primitive impulses and controlling them... Exodus 33:22 says, "VeSakoti Kapi Aleicha," I will shelter you with my hand (Krias HaTorah)."

The shape of the shofar, which calls us to repentance on Rosh Hashanah, must - according to halachic tradition - have a bent shape to indicate that a person's evil spirit must be bent as a prerequisite for repentance. However, the shofar blown in the Temple every fifty years to announce the Yovel, Jubilee Year, is long and straight as a symbol of freedom (Rosh Hashanah 26b)...

"The Talmud (Yoma 35b) teaches that when Joseph withstood the enticements of Potiphar's wife, she threatened him with imprisonment, and exclaimed, 'Ani Kophephet Komatech," I will bend your [moral] steadfastness.' Joseph responded, 'Hashem Zokeph (with a final Kaf) Kephuphim,' Hashem straightens the bent. (Psalms 146:8)." (Munk, the Wisdom of the Hebrew Alphabet, p. 136)

This period also marks the end of the Counting of the Omer, in which we worked tirelessly on our animal inclinations, "straightening ourselves out," and preparing ourselves to receive the Torah on the fiftieth day, like the fiftieth year of the Yovel.

The Perek Shirah elements of this week are also related to Shavuot. Shavuot is known also as Chag HaBikurim, the Festival of the First Fruits, whenthe first fruits of the seven species with which the Land of Israel is blessed were harvested and brought to the Temple. It is therefore quite appropriate that in include the Trees of the Field in general as well as the Vine, which is the first (and arguably the most important) of the seven species. Shavuot is also called Chag HaKatzir, the Harvest Festival, and the third Chapter of Perek Shirah, which begins with this cycle, is all about the vegetable kingdom.

The verses of these two elements read as follows (translation from Rabbi Slifkin):

The Wild Trees are saying, "Then shall the trees of the forest sing out at the presence of G-d, because He comes to judge the earth." (Chronicles I 16:33)

The Vine is saying, "So says God: As the wine is found in the cluster, and one says: Do not destroy it, for a blessing is in it - so shall I do for the sake of my servants, so as not to destroy everything." (Isaiah 65:8)

The trees sing out in when they experience the present of G-d, just as we celebrate our encounter with G-d on Mount Sinai.

Rabbi Slifkin explains that the Vine takes much labor to plant and to harvest, and to later produce its final outcome: wine. Yet, the greater amount of work brings about an even greater reward. ("Nature's Song, p. 170) Similarly, on Shavuot, we are repaid for all the hard work that took place during the Counting of the Omer.

Both verses also contain a strong element of judgement, tempered by Hashem's mercy. As much as Shavuot is a day of celebration, the unfortunate events that took place immediately following the giving of the Torah (ie. the sin of the golden calf), required Hashem's great mercy, as well as Moshe's begging on our behalf "not to destroy everything."

The Temple guard for these 22 days is connected to the priestly family of Abiyah. This priestly family was given the eighth portion, and Shavuot is connected to the "eighth week," which is closely connected to the number fifty as well.

THIRTEENTH CYCLE

Mem Sofit

from 25th of Sivan to 16th of Tammuz

Fig and Pomegranate

3. One who learns from his fellow a single chapter, or a single law, or a single verse, or a single word, or even a single letter, he must treat him with respect. For so we find with David, king of Israel, who did not learn anything fromAchitofel except for two things alone, yet he called him his "master," his "guide" and his "intimate," as is stated (Psalms 55:14), "And you are a man of my worth, my guide and intimate friend." Surely we can infer a fortiori: if David, king of Israel, who learned nothing from Achitofel except for two things alone, nevertheless referred to him as his master, guide and intimate, it certainly goes without saying that one who learns from his fellow a single chapter, a law, a verse, a saying, or even a single letter, is obligated to revere him. And there is no reverence but Torah, as is stated (Proverbs 3:35; 28:10), "The sages shall inherit honor" "and the integral shall inherit good"; and there is no good but Torah, as is stated (ibid. 4:2), "I have given you a good purchase; My Torah, do not forsake it."

4. Such is the way of Torah: Bread with salt you shall eat, water in small measure you shall drink, and upon the ground you shall sleep; live a life of deprivation and toil in Torah. If so you do, "fortunate are you, and good is to you" (Psalms 128:2): fortunate are you in this world, and it is good to you in the World To Come.

The thirteenth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the end-letter Mem (Mem Sofit), as well as the Fig and the Pomegranate in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period runs from the end of Sivan to the day before the 17th of Tammuz.

As mentioned previously, the Mem is one of the "mother-letters" in Kabbalah and stands for Em (mother) and Mayim (water). While the regular "open" Mem is connected to the revealed aspects of Creation and of the Torah, the Mem Sofit is "sealed," representing that which is hidden and concealed. It is also a reference the

final redeemer Mashiach, while the regular Mem is a reference to the first redeemer, Moshe.

The numerical value of the letter Mem is 40. This period appears to be particularly connected to the number 40. It includes the second half of the 40 days in which Moshe was at Har Sinai and the first part of the 40 days in which the spies were in the Land of Israel.

The thirteenth cycle includes Week 40 (Mem) and all but the last day of Week 41 (Mem Alef), which spells Em. It also marks a time on the Jewish calendar where Hashem is not longer as revealed (such as on Shavuot). Instead, Hashem is concealed, and we must battle through these days with great Emunah and strong belief in the coming of the final redeemer.

A similar theme can be found regarding the elements in Perek Shirah:

The Fig is saying: "The one who guards the fig shall eat of her fruits." (Proverbs 27:18)

The Pomegranate is saying, "Your cheeks are like a piece of a pomegranate behind your veil." (Song of Songs 4:3)

The fig is a fruit whose taste lasts a long time in one's mouth. This symbolizes how we must keep the memory of the revelations of Shavuot etched in our hearts. Rabbi Slifkin writes:"... fig trees ripen over a long period. The first ones ripen in late spring, at the time of the Shavuos festival, and the others ripen over the course of the entire summer." The very verse that the Fig sings is about guarding the Torah that one learns:

The pomegranate's song focuses on another point touched upon above: concealement. By looking at the outside of a pomegranate, one would never guess the shear number of seeds it contains - around 613 on average according to tradition, but nobody's counting. :) This is the meaning behind its verse as well:

The sinners of Israel are as full of mitzvos as a pomegranate, as is written, "Your cheeks are like a piece of pomegranate"; do not read "your cheeks" (rakosech) but "your empty ones" (rekanin shebach). (Talmud (Chagigah 27a); Slifkin, p. 180)

This is a time of the year when a lot can be accomplished, not only in the area of study, but also regarding practical mitzvot.

FOURTEENTH CYCLE

Nun Sofit

from 17th of Tammuz to Tisha B'Av

the Palm and the Tapuach (Etrog/Apple)

5. Do not seek greatness for yourself, and do not lust for honor. More than you study, do. Desire not the table of kings, for your table is greater than theirs, and your crown is greater than theirs, and faithful is your Employer to pay you the rewards of your work.

6. Torah is greater than the priesthood or sovereignty, for sovereignty is acquired with thirty virtues, the priesthood with twenty-four, and Torah is acquired with forty-eight qualities. These are: study, listening, verbalizing, comprehension of the heart, awe, fear, humility, joy, purity, serving the sages, companionship with one's contemporaries, debating with one's students, tranquility, study of the scriptures, study of the Mishnah, minimizing engagement in business, minimizing socialization, minimizing pleasure, minimizing sleep, minimizing talk, minimizing gaiety, slowness to anger, good heartedness, faith in the sages, acceptance of suffering, knowing one's place, satisfaction with one's lot, qualifying one's words, not taking credit for oneself, likableness, love of Gd, love of humanity, love of charity, love of justice, love of rebuke, fleeing from honor, lack of arrogance in learning, reluctance to hand down rulings, participating in the burden of one's fellow, judging him to the side of merit, correcting him, bringing him to a peaceful resolution [of his disputes], deliberation in study, asking and answering, listening and illuminating, learning in order to teach, learning in order to observe, wising one's teacher, exactness in conveying a teaching, and saying something in the name of its speaker. Thus we have learned: One who says something in the name of its speaker brings redemption to the world, as is stated (Esther 2:22), "And Esther told the king in the name of Mordechai."

The fourteenth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the end-letter Nun (Nun Sofit), as well as the Palm and the Tapuach (Etrog/Apple) in Perek Shirah. This

22-day period coincides with the Three Weeks of mourning from the the fast of the 17th of Tammuz to the fast of the 9th of Av. This cycle is a microcosm of the entire year, similar to the Counting of the Omer; it also contains the yahrzeit of the Ari HaKadosh on the 5th of Av and the birth of Mashiach on the 9th of Av.

As mentioned previously, the Nun stands for the Divine attribute (sefirah) of Malchut, Kingship, and is related to one of the names for Mashiach: Yinon. (Likutei Moharan) Nun also means "fish" in Aramaic, and is associated closely with Moshe. Joshua is called Yehoshua Bin Nun, the son of Nun, because a teacher (in this case, Moshe) is like a parent. The Nun also represents the idea of a faithful servant. While the regular Nun is bent, the final Nun is an unbounded straight line, reaching even below the "resting place" of the regular letters. (Rabbi Ginsburgh) The final Nun represents Mashiach's ability to infuse even the lowliest of realms with G-dliness. The final Nun also has the shape of an extended vav, which stands for uprightness.

Much of the suffering the Jewish people has endured during these three weeks is to lead us to a state of uprightness. These three weeks are also very much associated with the coming of Mashiach, who will be the ultimate example of such uprightness.

The above also appears to parallel the song of the animal for week 42 (Book 1), the hound, which starts on the 18th of Tammuz. The hound's verse is "Let the righteous rejoice in G-d; praise is befitting to the upright." (Psalms 33:1)

A similar theme can be found regarding the elements in Perek Shirah.

The Palm is saying, "The righteous will flourish like the palm tree; they will grow like a cedar in Lebanon." (Psalms 92:13)

The Tapuach (Esrog/Apple) is saying, "Like the Tapuach tree among the trees of the woods, so is my beloved among young men. I sat down under his shadow with delight, and his fruit was sweet to my taste." (Song of Songs 2:3)

The Palm tree is straight and upright, compared in the verse to the Tzadik. The cedar, also mentioned in this verse, is also tall and strong. Levanon, mentioned in this verse, is also a reference to the Temple. The first and second temples were destroyed during this time of the year because of corruption. The third one will be rebuilt when the Jewish people will be straight and upright, and will last forever.

The Tapuach, whether it represents the Etrog or the Apple, is associated with the Garden of Eden - a state of closeness with G-d, which we will reach in the Messianic era.

FIFTEENTH CYCLE

Peh Sofit

from 10th of Av to Rosh Chodesh Elul

Sheaves of Barley and Sheaves of Wheat

7. Great is Torah, for it gives life to its observers in this world, and in the World To Come. As is stated (Proverbs 4:22): "For they are life to he who finds them, and a healing to all his flesh." And it says (ibid. 3:8): "It shall be health to your navel, and marrow to your bones." And it says (3:18): "She is a tree of life for those who hold fast to her, and happy are those who support her." And it says (1:9): "For they shall be a garland of grace for your head, and necklaces about your neck." And it says(4:9): "She shall give to your head a garland of grace, a crown of glory she shall grant you." And it says (9:11): "With me, your days shall be increased, and years of life shall be added to you." And it says (3:16): "Long days in her right hand; in her left, wealth and honor." And it says (3:2): "For long days, years of life and peace, they shall add to you."

8. Rabbi Shimon the son of Judah would say in the name of Rabbi Shimon the son of Yochai: Beauty, strength, wealth, honor, wisdom, sageness, old age and children are becoming to the righteous and becoming to the world. As is stated (Proverbs 16:31): "Old age is a crown of beauty, to be found in the ways of righteousness." And it says (ibid. 20:29): "The beauty of youths is their strength, and the glory of sages is their age." And it says (ibid., 17:6): "The crown of sages are their grandchildren, and the beauty of children their fathers." And it says (Isaiah 24:23): "And the moon shall be abashed and the sun shamed, for the L-rd of hosts has reigned in Zion, and before his elders is glory."

Rabbi Shimon the son of Menasia would say: these seven qualities enumerated by the sages for the righteous were all realized in Rabbi [Judah HaNassi] and his sons.

The fifteenth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the end-letter Peh (Peh Sofit) as well as the Sheaves of Wheat and the Sheaves of Barley in Perek Shirah. This

22-day period runs from the day immediately following the Three Weeks of mourning, the 10th of Av, until Rosh Chodesh Elul.

As mentioned previously, the Peh stands for "mouth," and its shape is that of a mouth as well. The final Peh symbolizes a mouth that is wide open.

This period, after the difficulties and humbling experiences endured over the last three weeks and particularly beginning with the month of Elul (in which "the King is in the field"), is one in which we must open our mouths wide in prayer and personal supplications to G-d. It is also a time in which we seek to communicate better with one another (Av as a whole is a month connected to the spiritual rectification "tikkun" of our sense of hearing, listening to one another).

Furthermore, the Peh is formed by a combination of the Kaf and a Yud. The Yud stands for Godliness, and therefore the Peh symbolizes the revelation of Godliness. The more open lines of communication described above lead inevitably to a greater revelation of Godliness in ourselves as well.

This cycle includes Tu B'Av, which is known to be the happiest and most romantic day on the Jewish calendar. It was at this time that the Tribes of Israel were once again allowed to intermarry among themselves. To celebrate this day, young Jewish women would dress in white, form a circle, and present themselves before the single men of the community that were in search of a bride. The Talmud teaches that each woman would speak of different qualities that they thought might make a good impression on a potential groom. This is related to the tikkun of the sense of hearing connected to this month, and also the revelation of our positive qualities and the G-dliness within us.

As in prevoius weeks, there also appears to be a parallel between the relationship of the regular Peh with the final Peh and that of Moshe and Mashiach. Moshe was very much connected to the mouth. The Torah states that he had "uncircumsized lips," in that he would stammer. Mashiach will be someone known for his Torah and his speech. The word Mashiach is spelled the same as Mesiach, one who speaks, converses. He will teach the world how to properly converse with G-d. Similar to the final Nun, the long downward "leg" of the final Peh appears to represent Mashiach's ability to infuse even the lowliest of realms with the revelation of G-dliness.

A similar theme can be found regarding the elements in Perek Shirah.

The Sheaves of Wheat are saying, “A song of ascents: Out of the depths have I cried to you, O God.” (Psalms 130:1)

The Sheaves of Barley are saying, “A prayer of the pauper, when he swoons, and pours out his speech before God.” (Psalms 102:1)

Both songs above contain within them a sense of desolation, difficulty, and great humility. Both songs also emphasize the sense of speech - crying out to God and pouring out one’s speech before Him. Both sheaves of wheat and barley contain in them a potential to become food, but they nonetheless require much growth and “processing.”

The sense of humility described above also appears to parallel the humble outlook of the animals for weeks 45 and 46 (Book 1), the creeping creatures and the prolific creeping creatures.

SIXTEENTH CYCLE

Tzadik Sofit

from 2nd of Elul to 23rd of Elul

Other Sheaves and Vegetables of the Field

9. Said Rabbi Yossei the son of Kisma: Once, I was traveling and I encountered a man. He greeted me and I returned his greetings. Said he to me: "Rabbi, where are you from?" Said I to him: "From a great city of sages and scholars, am I." Said he to me: "Rabbi, would you like to dwell with us in our place? I will give you a million dinars of gold, precious stones and pearls." Said I to him: "If you were to give me all the silver, gold, precious stones and pearls in the world, I would not dwell anywhere but in a place of Torah. Indeed, so is written in the book of psalms by David the king of Israel: 'I prefer the Torah of Your mouth over thousands in gold and silver' (Psalms 119:72). Furthermore, when a person passes from this world neither silver, nor gold, nor precious stones, nor pearls accompany him, only Torah and good deeds, as is stated (Proverbs 6:22): 'When you go it will direct you, when you lie down it will watch over you, and when you awaken it shall be your speech.' 'When you go it will direct you'---in this world; 'when you lie down it will watch over you'---in the grave; 'and when you awaken it shall be our speech'---in the World To Come. Also it says (Chaggai 2:8): 'Mine is the silver and Mine is the gold, so says the L-rd of Hosts.' "

10. Gd acquired five acquisitions in his world. These are: one acquisition is the Torah, one acquisition are the heavens and the earth, one acquisition isAbraham, one acquisition is the people of Israel, and one acquisition is the Holy Temple. The Torah, as it is written (Proverbs 8:22), "Gd acquired me as the beginning of His way, before His works of yore." The heavens and the earth, as it is written (Isaiah 66:1), "So says Gd: The heavens are My throne and the earth is My footstool; what house, then, can you build for Me, and where is My place of rest?"; and it says (Psalms 104:25), "How many are your works, O Gd, You have made them all with wisdom; the earth is filled with Your acquisitions." Abraham, as it is written (Genesis 14:19), "And he

blessed him, and said: Blessed be Abram to Gd Most High, acquirer of heavens and earth." Israel, as it is written (Exodus 15:16), "Till Your nation, O Gd, shall pass, till this nation You have acquired shall pass"; and it says (Psalms 16:3), "To the holy who are upon earth, the noble ones, in whom is all My delight." The Holy Temple, as it is written (Exodus 15:17), "The base for Your dwelling that you, Gd, have achieved; the Sanctuary, O L-rd, that Your hands have established"; and it says (Psalms 78:54), "And He brought them to His holy domain, this mount His right hand has acquired."

The sixteenth set of 22 days of the Jewish calendar parallels the end-letter Tzadik (Tzadik Sofit), as well as the "Other Sheaves" and the Vegetables of the Field in Perek Shirah. This 22-day period runs through the 23rd of Elul.

As mentioned previously, Tzadik means righteous. The shape of the regular Tzadik is bent, while that of the end-letter Tzadik is straight and goes further down than the resting place of other letters. Elul is the month of Teshuvah, and the Tzadik Sofit represents the Ba'al Teshuvah. Someone who went down below to then climb back up. When Mashiach comes, even Tzadikim will do Teshuvah. Moshe is the quintessential Tzadik. The Tzadik Sofit, the "end Tzadik, is a reference to Mashiach. Mashiach will elevate even the lowest of realms.

The Tzadi Sofit is also found in the word for land, Eretz, which our sages teach are a reference to the World to Come, Olam HaBah.

"Kol yisrael yesh lahem chelek b'olam haba, sh'nemar, "v'amech kulam tzadikim, l'olam yirshu ha'aretz; netzer matai, ma'aseh yadai l'hitpaer." (transl: "Every member of Israel has a portion in the world-to-come, as it states (in Isaiah 60:21), "Your people are all righteous, they shall inherit the land forever; they are the branch of my planting, the work of my hands, so that I may be glorified.").

Any Jew - even one whose sins have caused him to forfeit his share in the World to Come - can regain his loss if he repents. Through repentance, any Jew can attain the rank of Tzadik and be worthy of a share in Eretz, the World to Come (Rambam, Hil. Teshuvah 3:14). (Rabbi Munk, p. 193)

The Tzadik's connection to land goes further. Land is constant, humble, ready to receive rain. The same is true for the righteous, as well as for all of us who engage in Teshuvah during the month of Elul.

A similar theme can be found regarding the elements in Perek Shirah:

The Other Sheaves are saying, “The meadows are clothed with flocks; the valleys also are covered over with grain; they shout for joy, they also sing” (Psalms 65:14)

The Vegetables of the Field are saying, “You water its furrows abundantly; You settle its ridges; you make it soft with showers; You bless its growth” (Psalms 65:11)

Both songs are from the same Psalm. Their central theme is visualizing ourselves in the way we are meant to be: Tzadikim, like a land clothed with flock and grain, singing and shouting with joy. It also about making ourselves ready to receive water (a reference to Torah), making furrows and ridges, making ourselves soft with rain, and growing.

ADDITIONAL HALF CYCLE

The Vowels

from the 24th of Elul to 6th of Tishrei

The Grass

11. Everything that Gd created in His world, He did not create but for His glory. As is stated (Isaiah 43:7): "All that is called by My name and for My glory, I created it, formed it, also I made it." And it says (Exodus 15:1): "Gd shall reign forever and ever."

An additional set, containing 12 days, parallels the Hebrew vowels, as well as "the Grasses" in Perek Shirah. These twelve days include the first days of creation, as well as those of Rosh Hashanah of the coming year, up to the 6th day of Tishrei.

As previously explained, the Grasses were not an original part of Perek Shirah. They were added by Rabbi Yaakov Emden. The verse was "found in an incorrect location" in some versions of Perek Shirah, and therefore transferred to an appropriate location the end of the Chapter 3, based on Talmud in Chullin 60a. (Slifkin, p. 199)

Similarly, it would not appear necessary to discuss the Hebrew vowels. Nevertheless, the twelve vowels bring the total count of the calendar to 364 days, which equals 52 weeks, the number of weeks in a solar year. There are 52 animals in Chapters 4 - 6 of Perek Shirah, one for each week of the year. (See Book I of the Kabbalah of Time)

The Hebrew vowels parallel the Kabbalistic sefirot. They give additional sound to the letters, allowing for a much greater diversity of sounds and words.

Similarly, the song of the Grasses is about diversity: The Grasses are saying, "May the glory of G-d endure forever; may G-d rejoice in His works." (Slifkin, p. 198)

As mentioned previously, this verse is derived from a passage in the Tractate of Chullin (60a). This passage is closely linked with Creation, which took place during these days:

“May the glory of G-d endure forever; may G-d rejoice in His works,” - this verse was uttered by the angel of the world. At the time when the Holy One said “according to its kind” to the trees, the grasses reasoned a fortiori: “If the Holy One wants intermingling, then why did He say 'according to its kind’ for the trees? And furthermore, if with trees, which do not usually grow intermingled, the Holy One said, 'according to its kind,' then how much more so does this apply to us!” Immediately each emerged according to its kind. The angel of the world opened with, “May the glory of G-d endure forever; may G-d rejoice in His works.”

The song is sung at the time of creation, sung by the “angel of the world” itself. The song is about G-d’s glory, His Kavod.Pirkei Avot concludes by stating that the entire world was created solely for His glory:

Everything that G-d created in His world, He did not create but for His glory. As is stated (Isaiah 43:7): “All that is called by My name and for My glory, I created it, formed it, also I made it.” And it says (Exodus 15:1): “G-d shall reign forever and ever.” (Chapter 6:11)